Hallucination in LLMs

Mitigating Hallucination

Trustworthy Large Language Models

ELL8299 · COL8383 · COL873



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This Lecture

01

Why?

Understanding the causes of hallucination

02

How much?

Benchmarking and measuring hallucination

03

What can we do?

Methods for mitigating hallucination

	No External Knowledge	External Knowledge / Tools
Inference-Time		
Post-Generation		

	No External Knowledge	External Knowledge / Tools
Inference-Time	Factual Nucleus Sampling	
Post-Generation		

Factual Nucleus Sampling

[Factual Prompt] One of lung cancer's symptoms is shortness of breath.
[Greedy] The American Cancer Society estimates that more than 228,000 people will be diagnosed with lung cancer in the United States this year.\n\n ~~The American Cancer Society estimates that more than 228,000 people will be diagnosed with lung cancer in the United States this year.\n\nThe American Cancer Society estimates that more than 228,000 people will be diagnosed with lung cancer in the United...~~
[p=0.9] That would make an oxygen mask one of the more popular treatments for this devastating disease. It helps ease breathing and give patients back their strength. Learn more here.<|endoftext|>"

Source: Factuality Enhanced Language Models for Open-Ended Text Generation. Lee et. al., NeurIPS 2023

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[p=0.9] That would make an oxygen mask one of the more popular treatments for this devastating disease. It helps ease breathing and give patients back their strength. Learn more here.<|endoftext|>"

[Non-Factual Prompt] Cancer can be prevented by drinking too much alcohol.

[Greedy] \nCancer can be prevented by eating too much red meat.\n\n~~Cancer can be prevented by eating too much~~ sugar.~~\n\nCancer can be prevented by eating too much~~ fat.~~\n\nCancer can be prevented by eating too much~~ processed food.~~\n\nCancer can be~~...

[p=0.9] More than 90% of hepatocellular carcinoma is associated with alcohol use.\n\nAbout 9 percent of cancers can be prevented if we don't eat more than 1.5 ounces of processed meat each day.\n\nDiet is believed to play a role in 7% of cancers and...

Source: Factuality Enhanced Language Models for Open-Ended Text Generation. Lee et. al., NeurIPS 2023

Factual Nucleus Sampling: Metrics Used

Named Entity Error Rate (NEER)

$$\text{NEER} = \frac{|\text{HALLU}_{\text{NE}}|}{|\text{ALL}_{\text{NE}}|}$$

ALL_{NE} = all named entities (NE) detected in the generation
HALLU_{NE} = NEs not found in the Wikipedia doc

"**Barack Obama**, born in **Honolulu**, graduated from **Harvard Law School** and later taught law at **Stanford University**."

Detected NE	In Wikipedia doc?
Barack Obama	✓ yes
Honolulu	✓ yes
Harvard Law School	✓ yes
Stanford University	✗ no (he taught at U. Chicago)

NEER = 1 / 4 = 25%

Intuition: generating a named entity absent from the ground-truth document = hallucination

Source: Factuality Enhanced Language Models for Open-Ended Text Generation. Lee et. al., NeurIPS 2023

Factual Nucleus Sampling: Metrics Used

Entailment Ratio (EntailR)

$$\text{EntailR} = \frac{|\text{ENTAIL}_{\text{gen}}|}{|\text{ALL}_{\text{gen}}|}$$

ALL_{gen} = all generated (check-worthy) sentences
$\text{ENTAIL}_{\text{gen}}$ = those an NLI model labels "entailment"

Generation	Retrieved evidence	NLI label
"Barack Obama was born in Hawaii."	"Obama was born in Honolulu, Hawaii."	Entail ✓
"Barack Obama was born in 1962."	"…born August 4, 1961…"	Contradict ✗
"Barack Obama was a keen chess player."	(nothing relevant)	Neutral ✗

EntailR = 1 / 3 = 33% (neutral counts against)

Intuition: a factual generation should be entailed by the ground-truth evidence

Source: Factuality Enhanced Language Models for Open-Ended Text Generation. Lee et. al., NeurIPS 2023

Factual Nucleus Sampling: Metrics Used

Metric	What it captures	How it is computed	Better
Diversity	Is the generation interesting and varied, not the same text every time?	Distinct 4-grams normalised by length, over 10 generations per prompt (160K generations)	↑ higher
Repetition	Does the generation degenerate into loops?	Count of repeated substrings at the end of generations (Holtzman et al., 2020)	↓ lower

Goal: high diversity, low repetition

Source: Factuality Enhanced Language Models for Open-Ended Text Generation. Lee et. al., NeurIPS 2023

Factual Nucleus Sampling

Factual prompts (8,000)

FEVER claims labelled SUPPORTED by Wikipedia

e.g. "Barack Obama was born in Hawaii ..."

Nonfactual prompts (8,000)

FEVER claims labelled REFUTED by Wikipedia

e.g. "Barack Obama was born in Kenya ..."

Model (top-p 0.9)	NEER factual	NEER nonfactual	EntailR factual	EntailR nonfactual
126M	63.7%	67.7%	0.9%	0.8%
1.3B	52.4%	56.8%	2.9%	2.0%
8.3B	40.6%	47.5%	7.1%	3.6%
530B	33.3%	40.5%	11.8%	7.3%

Takeaways

- Nonfactual prompts → **more** factual errors
- Even factual prompts yield 33–64% NEER
- Bigger models are more factual overall

Source: Factuality Enhanced Language Models for Open-Ended Text Generation. Lee et. al., NeurIPS 2023

Factual Nucleus Sampling

Randomness buys diversity, but one wrong token can make a whole sentence false

Size	Decoding	NEER ↓	EntailR ↑	Diversity ↑	Repetition ↓
126M	top-p 0.9	63.7%	0.9%	0.90	0.6%
126M	greedy	48.6%	8.4%	0.03	59.1%
1.3B	top-p 0.9	52.4%	2.9%	0.88	0.2%
1.3B	greedy	39.9%	12.9%	0.05	33.1%
530B	top-p 0.9	33.3%	11.8%	0.90	0.1%
530B	greedy	20.9%	31.9%	0.08	15.9%

Greedy decoding

Picks the most likely token: makes full use of parametric knowledge, so it is more factual. But the text is bland and repetitive.

Nucleus (top-p) sampling

Samples from the top tokens with cumulative probability p: diverse, but the added randomness causes factual errors.

Why?

"Barack Obama was born in **1961** → **1962**": one sampled token flips the fact

Source: Factuality Enhanced Language Models for Open-Ended Text Generation. Lee et. al., NeurIPS 2023

Factual Nucleus Sampling

Hypothesis: randomness hurts factuality more at the end of a sentence than at the start

"**Samuel Witwer's father is a Lutheran minister**." The start is harmless; the completion makes it false.

Source: Factuality Enhanced Language Models for Open-Ended Text Generation. Lee et. al., NeurIPS 2023

Factual Nucleus Sampling

Hypothesis: randomness hurts factuality more at the end of a sentence than at the start

"**Samuel Witwer's father is a Lutheran minister**." The start is harmless; the completion makes it false.

$$p_t = \max\{\omega, p \times \lambda^{t-1}\}$$

Symbol	Meaning
t	Token position within the current sentence
p	Initial nucleus (top-p) probability, e.g. 0.9
λ	Decay factor per token, e.g. 0.9
ω	Lower bound on p_t, e.g. 0.3

Source: Factuality Enhanced Language Models for Open-Ended Text Generation. Lee et. al., NeurIPS 2023

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ω	Lower bound on p_t, e.g. 0.3

t	1	2	3	5	8	10	12+
p_t	0.90	0.81	0.73	0.59	0.43	0.35	**0.30**

p = 0.9, λ = 0.9, ω = 0.3: the nucleus shrinks token by token until it hits the floor ω.

Same compute as standard top-p, applied at inference time only.

Source: Factuality Enhanced Language Models for Open-Ended Text Generation. Lee et. al., NeurIPS 2023

Factual Nucleus Sampling

1. λ-decay

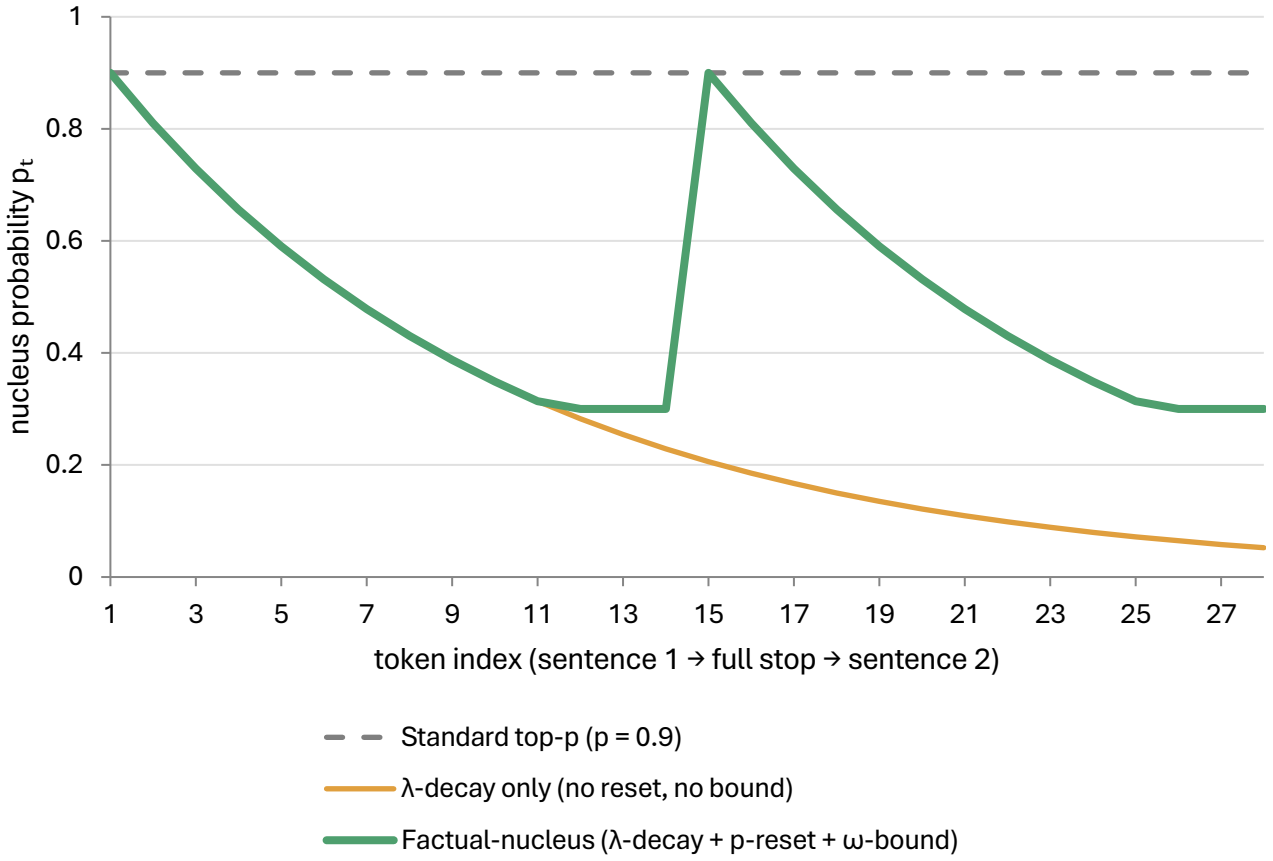
Shrink p by λ at each step: less randomness as the sentence becomes more determined

2. p-reset

Reset p to its initial value after a full stop. Without it, p decays to ≈ 0 and long texts become greedy (repetitive)

3. ω-bound

Floor on how far p can decay, so later tokens keep some diversity instead of collapsing to greedy



Source: Factuality Enhanced Language Models for Open-Ended Text Generation. Lee et. al., NeurIPS 2023

Factual Nucleus Sampling

1.3B LM, factual prompts

Decoding	p | λ | ω	NEER ↓	EntailR ↑	Div. ↑	Rep. ↓
Greedy	–	39.9%	12.9%	**0.05**	**33.1%**
Top-p	0.9	**52.4%**	**2.9%**	0.88	0.2%

Source: Factuality Enhanced Language Models for Open-Ended Text Generation. Lee et. al., NeurIPS 2023

Factual Nucleus Sampling

1.3B LM, factual prompts

Decoding	p | λ | ω	NEER ↓	EntailR ↑	Div. ↑	Rep. ↓
Greedy	–	39.9%	12.9%	**0.05**	**33.1%**
Top-p	0.9	**52.4%**	**2.9%**	0.88	0.2%
+ λ-decay	0.9 | 0.5	39.9%	13.0%	**0.08**	**33.1%**

Source: Factuality Enhanced Language Models for Open-Ended Text Generation. Lee et. al., NeurIPS 2023

Factual Nucleus Sampling

1.3B LM, factual prompts

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Greedy	–	39.9%	12.9%	**0.05**	**33.1%**
Top-p	0.9	**52.4%**	**2.9%**	0.88	0.2%
+ λ-decay	0.9 | 0.5	39.9%	13.0%	**0.08**	**33.1%**
+ p-reset	0.9 | 0.5	39.3%	12.8%	0.34	17.8%

Source: Factuality Enhanced Language Models for Open-Ended Text Generation. Lee et. al., NeurIPS 2023

Factual Nucleus Sampling

1.3B LM, factual prompts

Decoding	p | λ | ω	NEER ↓	EntailR ↑	Div. ↑	Rep. ↓
Greedy	–	39.9%	12.9%	**0.05**	**33.1%**
Top-p	0.9	**52.4%**	**2.9%**	0.88	0.2%
+ λ-decay	0.9 | 0.5	39.9%	13.0%	**0.08**	**33.1%**
+ p-reset	0.9 | 0.5	39.3%	12.8%	0.34	17.8%
+ ω-bound (FNS)	**0.9 | 0.9 | 0.3**	**42.1%**	**10.1%**	**0.55**	**7.1%**

Source: Factuality Enhanced Language Models for Open-Ended Text Generation. Lee et. al., NeurIPS 2023

Factual Nucleus Sampling

[Category] Company
[Factual Prompt] KFC is the second biggest restaurant chain in the world.

[Greedy] The company is owned by Yum! Brands, which also owns Pizza Hut and Taco Bell.\n\nKFC is known for its fried chicken, but it also offers other food items like chicken sandwiches, wraps, salads, and even rice bowls.\n\n~~KFC is known for its fried chicken, but it also offers other food items like chicken sandwiches, wraps, salads, and even rice bowls.\n\nKFC is known for its fried chicken, but it also offers other food items like chicken sandwiches, wraps, salads, and even rice bowls.\n\nKFC...~~

[p=0.9] While many restaurants worldwide have been growing their mobile commerce revenues, KFC chose to implement its payment system via cash. Customers must visit a traditional cash register to buy food.\n\nThe order-and-pay system that KFC had been using at its stores didn't allow customers to pay with their smartphones. Instead, customers have to stand in long lines to order and pay for their meals. The process involves taking a physical receipt, which is then placed at the counter, to process the order.\n\n...

[Ours] KFC was founded by Colonel Harland Sanders , an entrepreneur who began selling fried chicken from his roadside restaurant in Corbin , Kentucky , during the Great Depression . Sanders identified the potential of the restaurant franchising concept , and the first " Kentucky Fried Chicken " franchise opened in Utah in 1952 . KFC popularized chicken in the fast food industry , diversifying the market by challenging the established dominance of the hamburger . By branding himself as " Colonel Sanders " , Harland became a prominent figure of American cultural history , and his image remains widely used in KFC advertising to this day...

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	No External Knowledge	External Knowledge / Tools
Inference-Time	Factual Nucleus Sampling Context Aware Decoding (CAD)	
Post-Generation		

CAD: Context-Aware Decoding



Problem: when the context conflicts with the model's prior knowledge, the prior often wins

Source: Trusting Your Evidence: Hallucinate Less with Context-Aware Decoding. Shi et. al., NAACL 2024

CAD: Context-Aware Decoding

$$y_t \sim p_\theta(y_t|c, x, y_{<t}) \propto \exp \text{logit}_\theta(y_t|c, x, y_{<t})$$

Symbol	Meaning
c	Context: retrieved document / source to summarise
x	Query or instruction
$\mathbf{y_{<t}}$	Tokens generated so far
θ	LM parameters (= its prior / parametric knowledge)

Source: Trusting Your Evidence: Hallucinate Less with Context-Aware Decoding. Shi et. al., NAACL 2024

CAD: Context-Aware Decoding

$$\mathrm{PMI}(c; y_t) = \log \frac{p_\theta(y_t | c, x, y_{<t})}{p_\theta(y_t | x, y_{<t})}$$

Numerator: what the model believes **with** the context

Denominator: what it believes from prior knowledge alone (context removed)

PMI > 0 the context **supports** this token

PMI < 0 the context argues **against** it

PMI = 0 the context is irrelevant to it

Run the LM twice: with and without c

Token	p(y | c, x)	p(y | x)	ratio	PMI
Two	0.51	**0.84**	0.61	**−0.50**
Three	0.42	0.04	**9.97**	**+2.30**
One	0.07	0.11	0.61	**−0.50**

Without the context, the model is sure it's "Two": that is the stale prior.

Adding the context makes "Three" **10× more likely**, so PMI singles it out.

Source: Trusting Your Evidence: Hallucinate Less with Context-Aware Decoding. Shi et. al., NAACL 2024

CAD: Context-Aware Decoding

$$y_t \sim \tilde{p}_\theta(y_t|c,x,y_{<t}) \propto p_\theta(y_t|c,x,y_{<t}) \cdot \left(\frac{p_\theta(y_t|c,x,y_{<t})}{p_\theta(y_t|x,y_{<t})}\right)^{\alpha}$$

$$\log \tilde{p}_\theta(y_t|c,x,y_{<t}) = \log p_\theta(y_t|c,x,y_{<t}) + \alpha \cdot \mathrm{PMI}(c;y_t) + \mathrm{const}$$

Term	Role
p(y | c, x)	Expert 1: normal decoding (fluency, grammar)
(ratio)^α	Expert 2: PMI, rewards what the context adds
α	How much to trust the context over the prior

α	Behaviour
0	Regular decoding (PMI switched off)
0.5	Paper default: summarization
1	Knowledge-conflict QA (prior must be overridden)

A product of experts. Not yet a valid distribution: it must be normalised over the vocabulary

Source: Trusting Your Evidence: Hallucinate Less with Context-Aware Decoding. Shi et. al., NAACL 2024

CAD: Context-Aware Decoding

$$y_t \sim \tilde{p}_\theta(y_t|c, x, y_{<t}) \propto p_\theta(y_t|c, x, y_{<t}) \cdot \left(\frac{p_\theta(y_t|c, x, y_{<t})}{p_\theta(y_t|x, y_{<t})}\right)^\alpha$$

$$= p_c(y_t) \cdot \left(\frac{p_c(y_t)}{p_x(y_t)}\right)^\alpha = \frac{p_c(y_t)^{1+\alpha}}{p_0(y_t)^\alpha}$$

Source: Trusting Your Evidence: Hallucinate Less with Context-Aware Decoding. Shi et. al., NAACL 2024

CAD: Context-Aware Decoding

$$y_t \sim \tilde{p}_\theta(y_t|c,x,y_{<t}) \propto p_\theta(y_t|c,x,y_{<t}) \cdot \left(\frac{p_\theta(y_t|c,x,y_{<t})}{p_\theta(y_t|x,y_{<t})}\right)^\alpha$$

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$$\log \tilde{p}_c(y_t) = (1+\alpha)\log p_c(y_t) - \alpha \log p_0(y_t)$$

$$= (1+\alpha)\,\mathrm{logit}_c(y_t) - \alpha\,\mathrm{logit}_0(y_t) + \text{constant}$$

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$$= (1+\alpha)\,\mathrm{logit}_c(y_t) - \alpha\,\mathrm{logit}_0(y_t) + \text{constant}$$

$$\tilde{p}_c(y_t) \sim \mathrm{softmax}\big((1+\alpha)\,\mathrm{logit}_c(y_t) - \alpha\,\mathrm{logit}_0(y_t)\big)$$

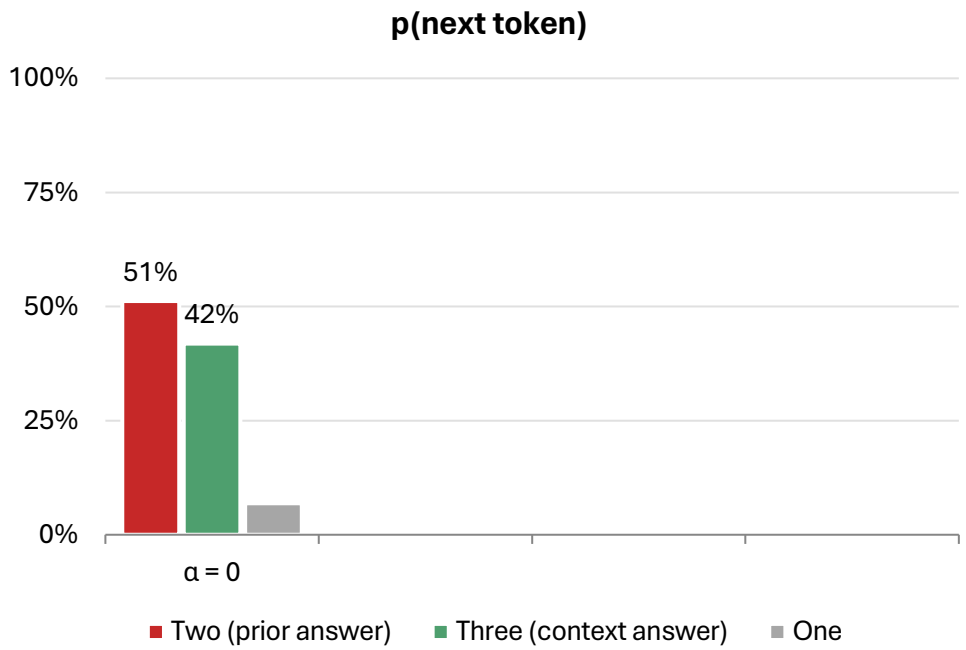
$$\tilde{p}_\theta(y_t|c,x,y_{<t}) \sim \mathrm{softmax}\big((1+\alpha)\,\mathrm{logit}_\theta(y_t|c,x,y_{<t}) - \alpha\,\mathrm{logit}_\theta(y_t|x,y_{<t})\big)$$

Source: Trusting Your Evidence: Hallucinate Less with Context-Aware Decoding. Shi et. al., NAACL 2024

CAD: Context-Aware Decoding

Token	logit(y | c, x)	logit(y | x)	CAD logit (α = 0)	p (α = 0)
Two	3.0	4.0	2.5	**0.51**
Three	2.8	1.0	**3.7**	0.42
One	1.0	2.0	0.5	0.07

CAD logit = 1 × logit(y | c, x) − 0 × logit(y | x)



Source: Trusting Your Evidence: Hallucinate Less with Context-Aware Decoding. Shi et. al., NAACL 2024

CAD: Context-Aware Decoding

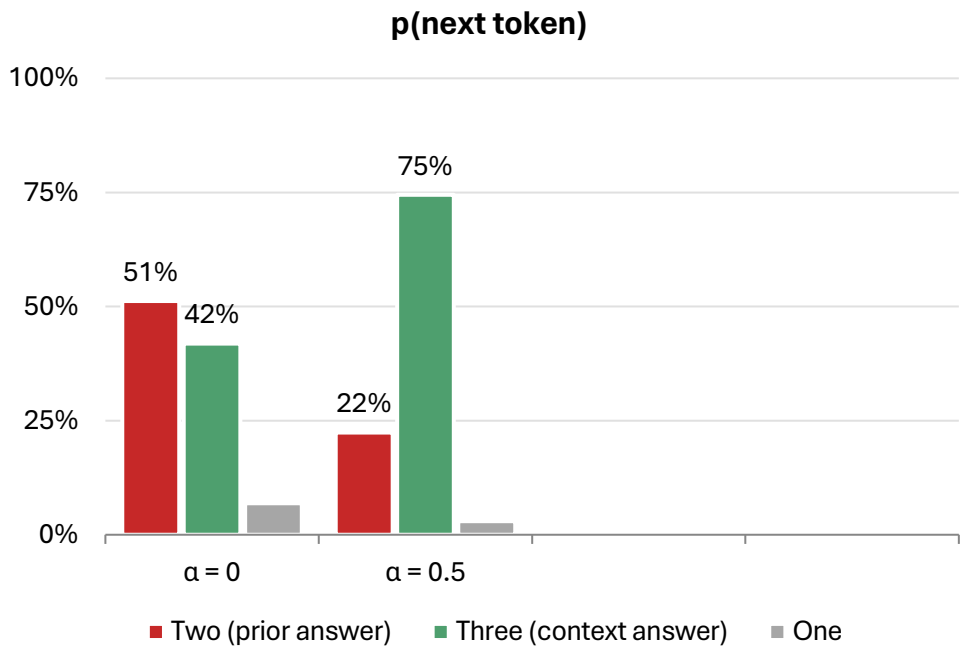
Token	logit(y | c, x)	logit(y | x)	CAD logit (α = 0.5)	p (α = 0.5)
Two	3.0	4.0	2.5	0.22
Three	2.8	1.0	**3.7**	**0.75**
One	1.0	2.0	0.5	0.03

CAD logit = 1.5 × logit(y | c, x) − 0.5 × logit(y | x)

Two: 1.5 × 3.0 − 0.5 × 4.0 = **2.5** prior was confident, so it's penalised

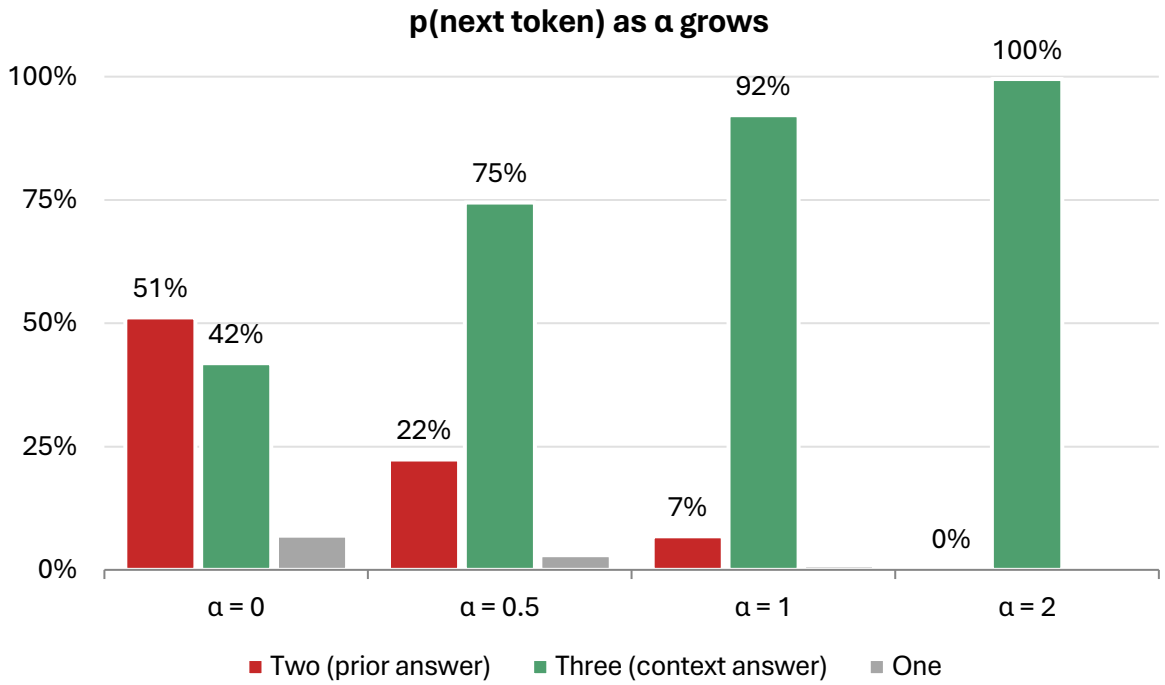
Three: 1.5 × 2.8 − 0.5 × 1.0 = **3.7** prior was unsure, the context is credited

One: 1.5 × 1.0 − 0.5 × 2.0 = 0.5



Source: Trusting Your Evidence: Hallucinate Less with Context-Aware Decoding. Shi et. al., NAACL 2024

CAD: Context-Aware Decoding



Larger α ⇒ more trust in the context

Source: Trusting Your Evidence: Hallucinate Less with Context-Aware Decoding. Shi et. al., NAACL 2024

CAD: Context-Aware Decoding

Summarization · XSUM, CNN-DM

α = 0.5

c: Article: Prison Link Cymru had 1,099 referrals in 2015-16 and said some ex-offenders were living rough ...

x: Summarize the article in one sentence. Summary:

Goal: no facts that are absent from the article

Metric: ROUGE-L, factKB, BERT-P

Knowledge conflict · NQ-SWAP

α = 1

c: Tesla CEO Elon Musk is now in charge of Twitter, CNBC has learned ...

x: Who is Twitter CEO now?

Gold answer swapped in the doc: follow the doc, not memory

Metric: Exact match

Memo. trap · MemoTrap

α = 1

c: Write a quote that ends in the word "early":

x: Better late than

Answer "early", not the memorised "never"

Metric: Exact match

Source: Trusting Your Evidence: Hallucinate Less with Context-Aware Decoding. Shi et. al., NAACL 2024

CAD: Context-Aware Decoding

Knowledge Conflicts · Exact Match

Model	MemoTrap	NQ	NQ-SWAP
OPT 30B	28.4 → 41.0	29.4 → 35.5	14.7 → 29.0
GPT-Neo 20B	37.1 → 57.3	22.8 → 32.1	**16.1 → 36.8**
LLaMA 30B	25.8 → 50.6	23.8 → 34.0	**9.6 → 37.7**
FLAN-T5 11B	82.0 → 88.7	**85.5 → 82.5**	73.0 → 77.1

Summarization · LLaMA 30B

Dataset	ROUGE-L	factKB	BERT-P
CNN-DM	25.8 → 31.8	**76.8 → 87.8**	88.5 → 92.2
XSUM	18.7 → 22.0	**47.7 → 66.4**	87.1 → 90.3

Regular → CAD

Biggest wins on conflicts

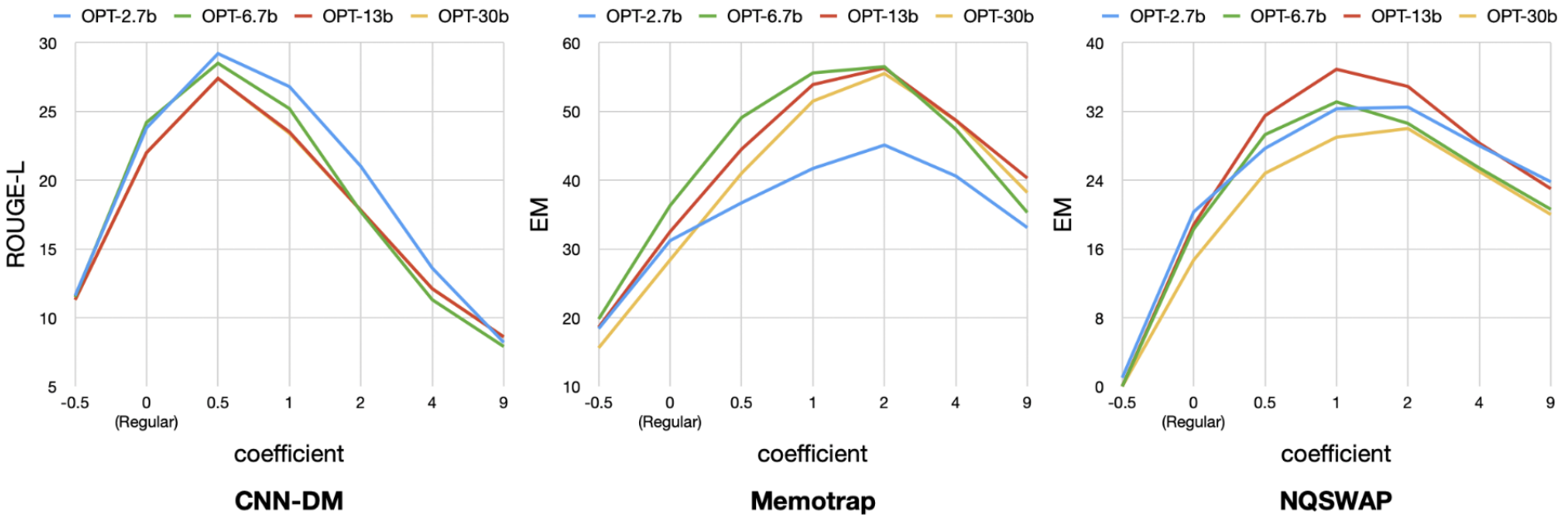
LLaMA-30B NQ-SWAP: 9.6 → 37.7 EM. GPT-Neo-20B: +128%

Faithful summaries

Better factKB and BERT-P

Source: Trusting Your Evidence: Hallucinate Less with Context-Aware Decoding. Shi et. al., NAACL 2024

CAD: Context-Aware Decoding



Effect of the adjustment level α. The y-axis is the performance and the x-axis is α.

Source: Trusting Your Evidence: Hallucinate Less with Context-Aware Decoding. Shi et. al., NAACL 2024

	No External Knowledge	External Knowledge / Tools
Inference-Time	Factual Nucleus Sampling Context Aware Decoding (CAD) Decoding by Contrasting Layers (DoLa)	
Post-Generation		

DoLa: Decoding by Contrasting Layers

Normal decoding uses the final layer

Normal decoding (final layer N)

$$p(x_t|x_{<t}) = \text{softmax}\left(\varphi\left(h_t^{(N)}\right)\right)_{x_t}$$

Symbol	Meaning
$\phi(\cdot)$	Vocabulary head (final affine layer → logits)
$h_t^{(j)}$	Hidden state of layer j at position t
N	Final Layer

Source: DoLa: Decoding by Contrasting Layers Improves Factuality in Large Language Models. Chuang et. al., ICLR 2024

DoLa: Decoding by Contrasting Layers

Normal decoding uses the final layer

Normal decoding (final layer N)

$$p(x_t|x_{<t}) = \text{softmax}\left(\varphi\left(h_t^{(N)}\right)\right)_{x_t}$$

Early exit at layer j

$$q_j(x_t|x_{<t}) = \text{softmax}\left(\varphi\left(h_t^{(j)}\right)\right)_{x_t}, \qquad j \in J$$

Symbol	Meaning
$\phi(\cdot)$	Vocabulary head (final affine layer → logits)
$h_t^{(j)}$	Hidden state of layer j at position t
N / M	Final Layer / Early Layer
J	Candidate early layers, e.g. [16, 32)

Source: DoLa: Decoding by Contrasting Layers Improves Factuality in Large Language Models. Chuang et. al., ICLR 2024

DoLa: Decoding by Contrasting Layers

Normal decoding uses the final layer

Normal decoding (final layer N)

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Q: "Where is the capital of Washington State?"

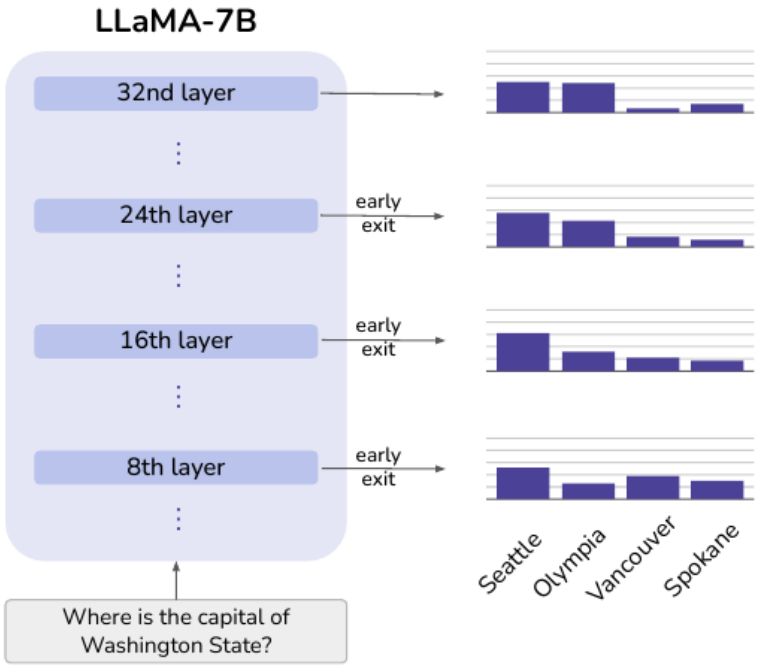
Layer	Seattle	Olympia	Vancouver	Spokane
q8	0.38	0.06	0.30	0.25
q16	0.55	0.08	0.20	0.17
q24	0.50	0.25	0.13	0.10
q32 = final	0.46	0.40	0.07	0.05

Example · early exit on LLaMA-7B (32 layers)

Source: DoLa: Decoding by Contrasting Layers Improves Factuality in Large Language Models. Chuang et. al., ICLR 2024

DoLa: Decoding by Contrasting Layers

Observation: factual knowledge "emerges" in the upper layers of the transformer



Q: "Where is the capital of Washington State?"

"Seattle" is likely at **every** layer: it is the famous, **plausible** Washington city

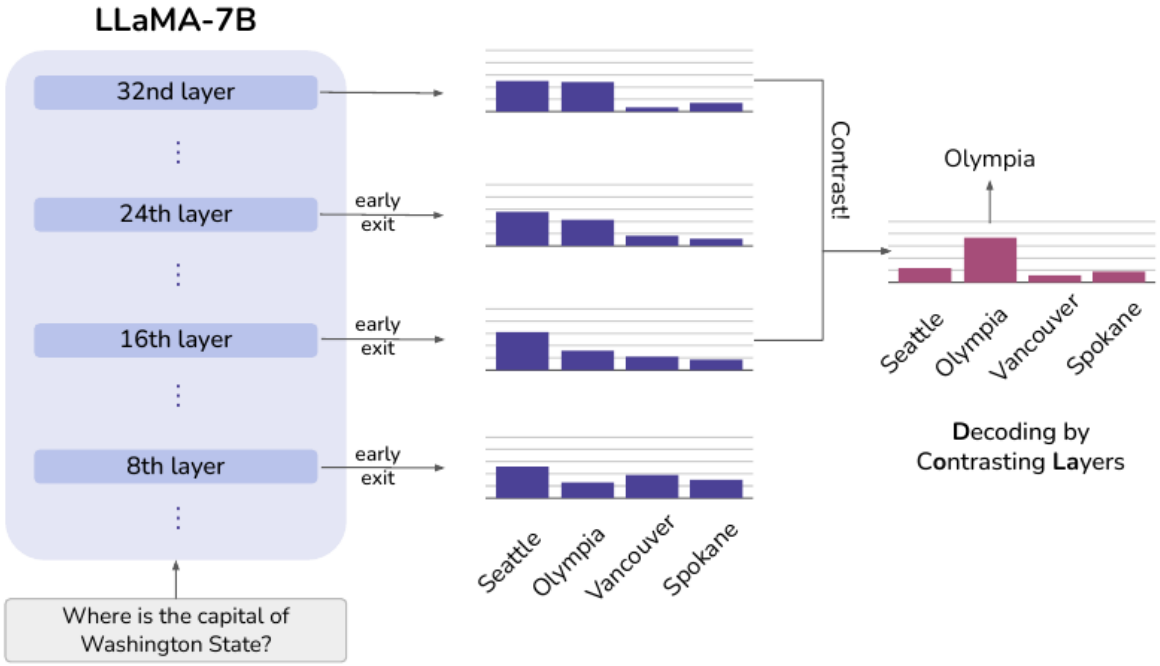
"Olympia" (correct) only grows in the **upper** layers, where facts are injected

Final layer alone: Seattle ≈ Olympia, a coin-flip

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Contrast top vs. lower layer: what **changed** is the fact, so Olympia wins

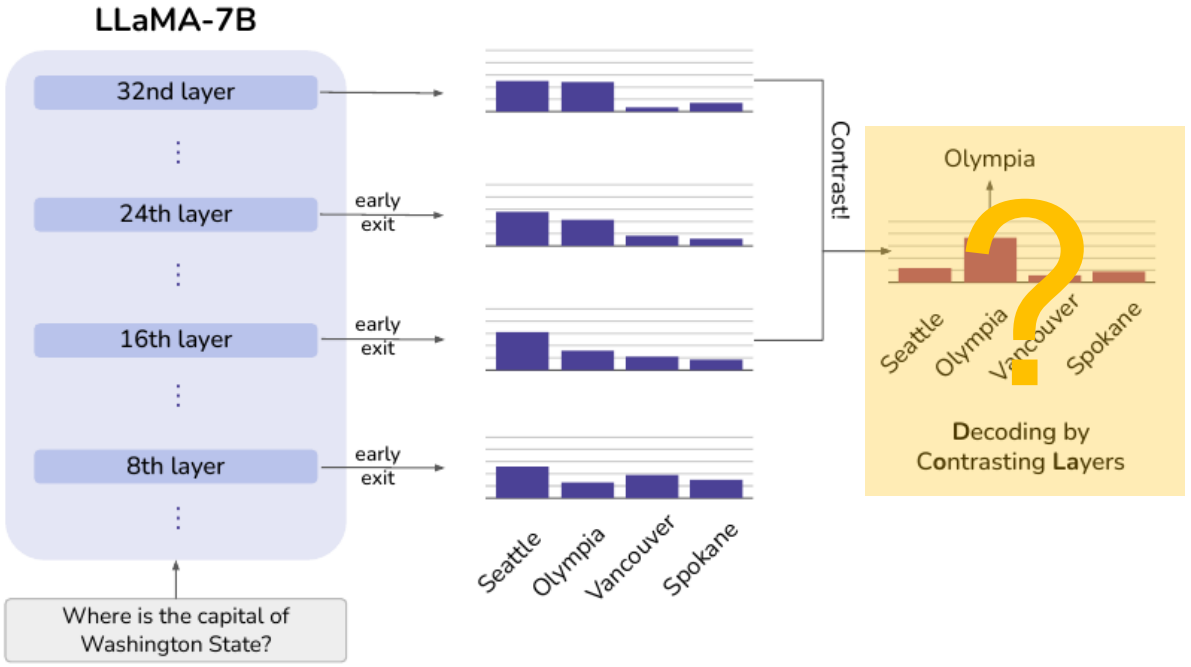
Early layers ≈ syntax / surface patterns; later layers ≈ semantics & facts (Tenney et al. 2019; Meng et al. 2022)

Idea: amplify what the upper layers add on top of the lower layers

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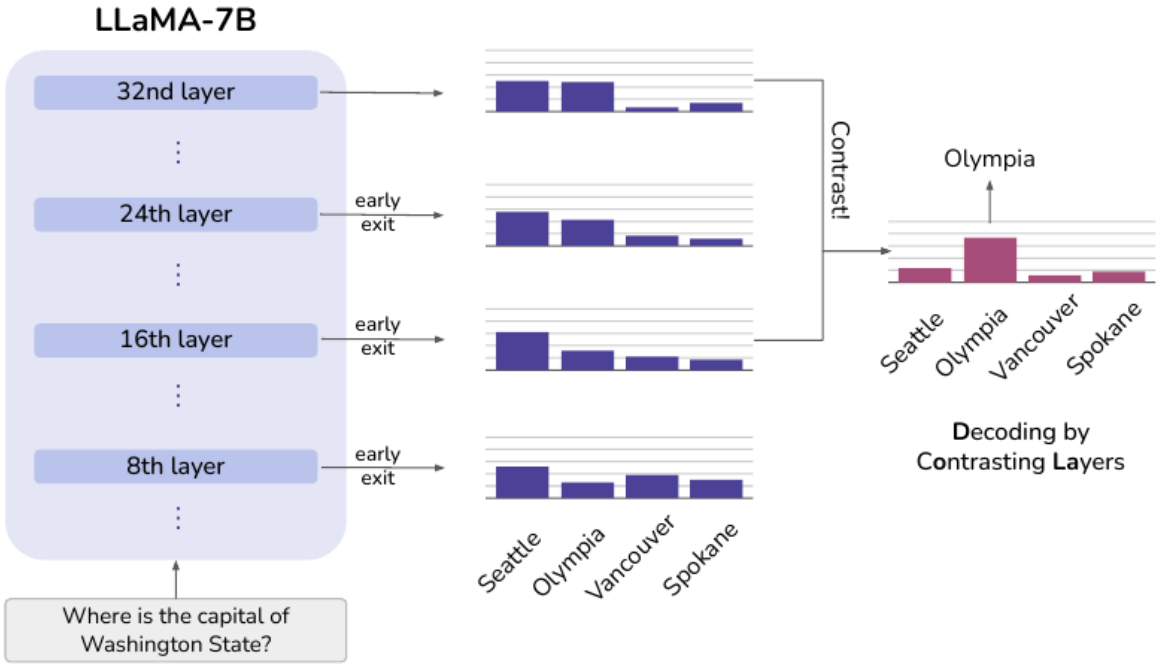
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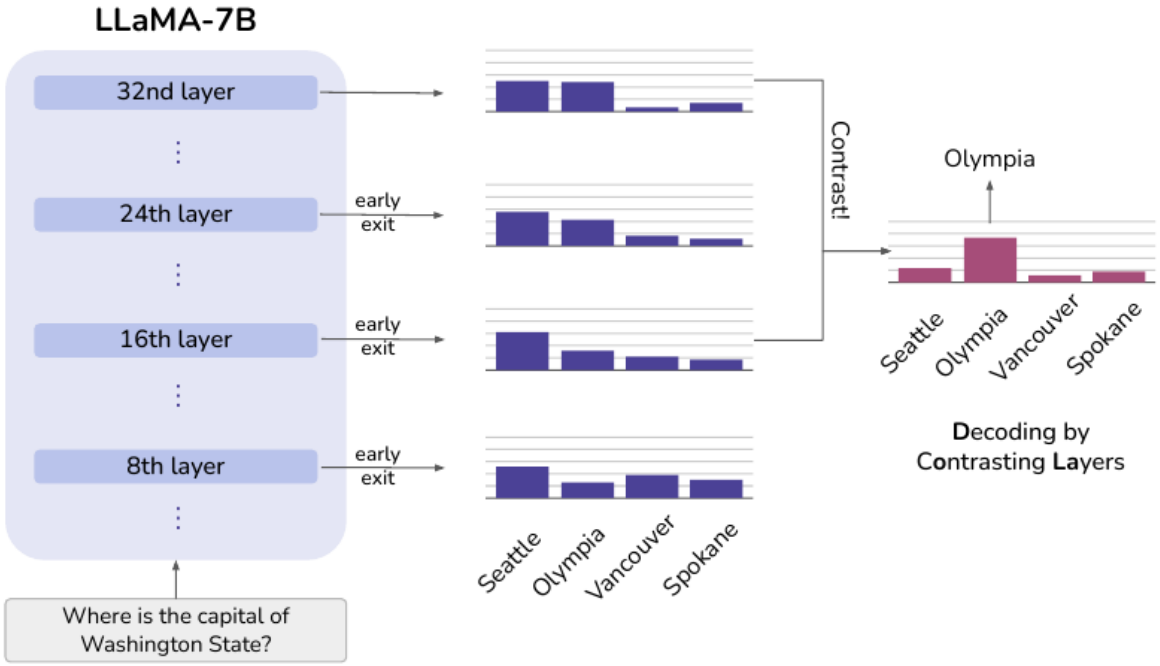
DoLa: Decoding by Contrasting Layers



$$\hat{p}(x_t|x_{<t}) = \text{softmax}\left(F\left(q_N(x_t), q_M(x_t)\right)\right)_{x_t}$$

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DoLa: Decoding by Contrasting Layers

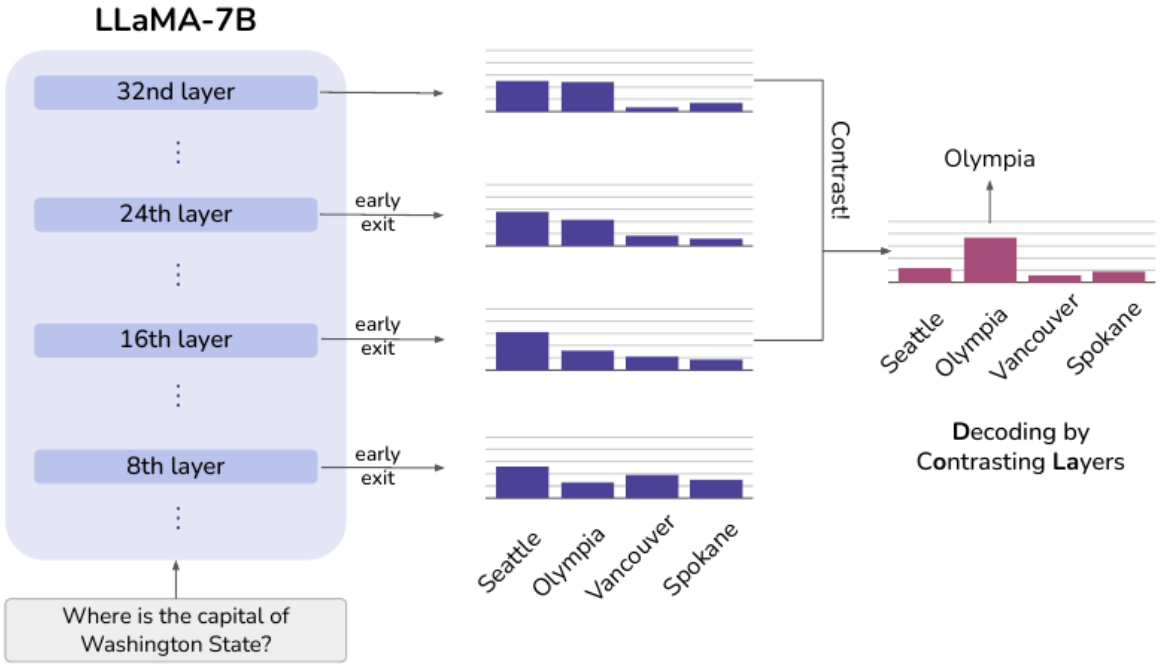


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DoLa: Decoding by Contrasting Layers



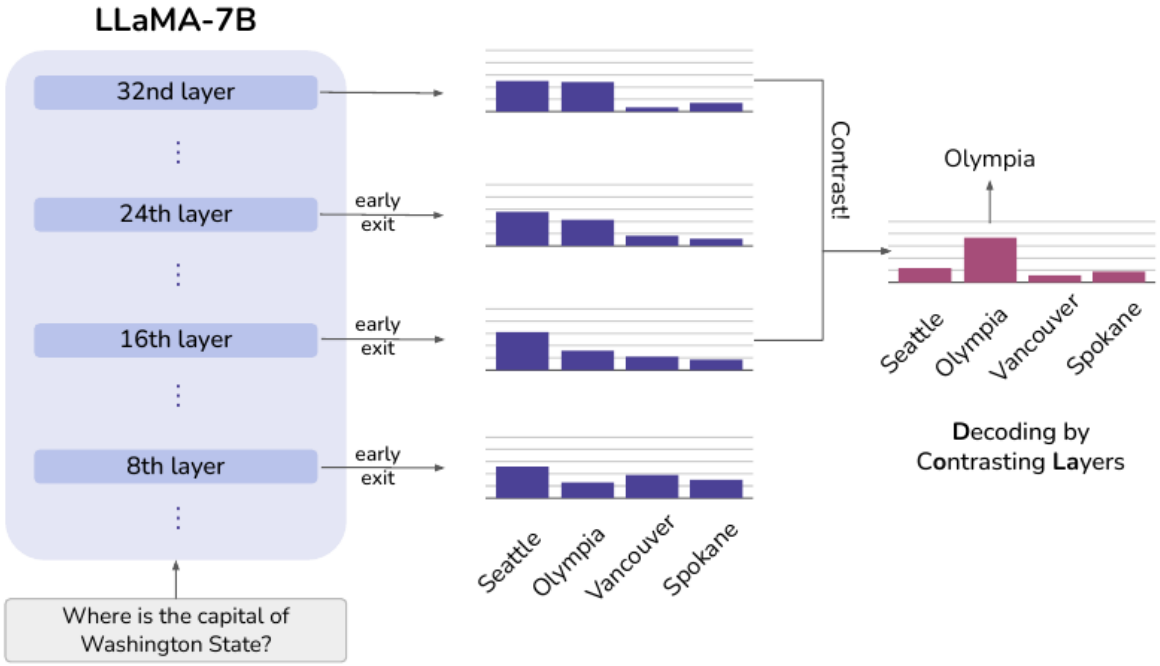
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How do we choose M?

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DoLa: Decoding by Contrasting Layers



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DoLa: Decoding by Contrasting Layers

Pick the premature layer M dynamically, at every decoding step

$$M = \arg\max_{j \in J} \; \mathrm{JSD}\left(q_N(\cdot\,|x_{<t}) \| q_j(\cdot\,|x_{<t})\right)$$

$\mathrm{JSD}\,(\cdot\,|\,\cdot)$ is the Jensen-Shannon divergence

Candidates J are a bucket of layers, chosen once per task on a validation set

Why the **most** different layer?

The model changes its output most after it, so that is where the fact was added

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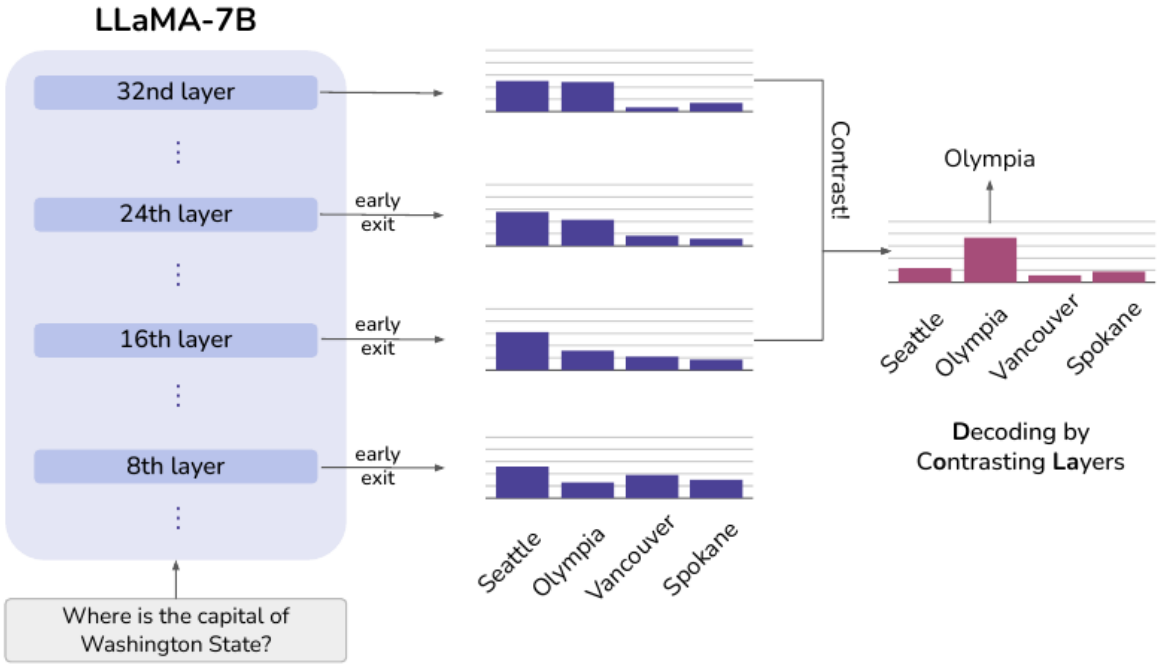
Example · bucket J = {5, 6,7}

Candidate j	JSD(q32 ‖ qj)	Selected?
4	0.148	out of bucket*
5	**0.099**	✓ M = 16
6	0.018	too similar
7	0.008	too similar

Model	Buckets J (even layers only)
LLaMA-7B (32)	[0, 16) · [16, 32)
LLaMA-65B (80)	[0, 20) · [20, 40) · [40, 60) · [60, 80)

Source: DoLa: Decoding by Contrasting Layers Improves Factuality in Large Language Models. Chuang et. al., ICLR 2024

DoLa: Decoding by Contrasting Layers



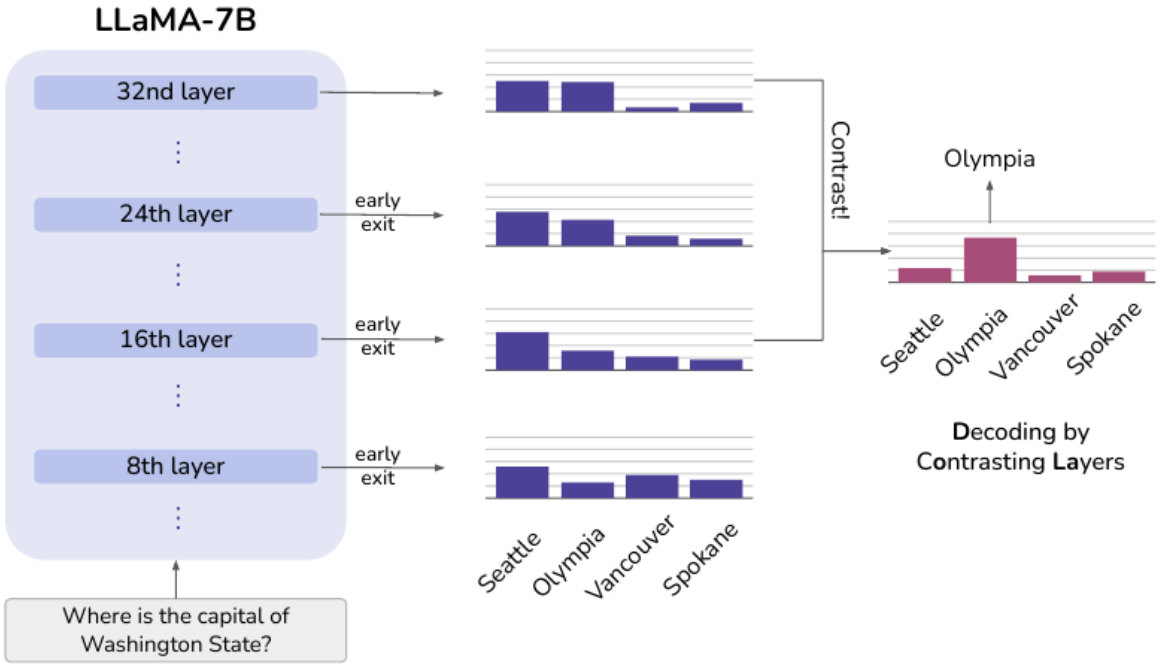
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DoLa: Decoding by Contrasting Layers



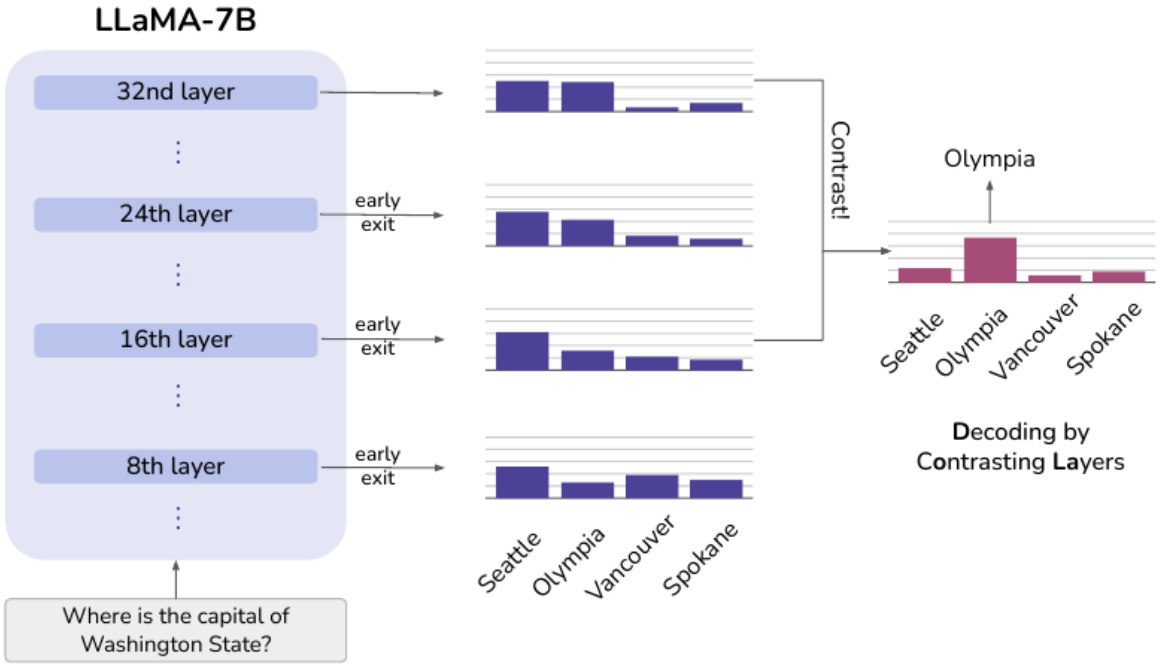
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Token	q32	q16	q32 / q16
Seattle	0.46	0.55	0.84
Olympia	0.40	0.08	5.0
Tacoma	0.02	0.001	20.0

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Token	q32	q16	q32 / q16
Seattle	0.46	0.55	0.84
Olympia	0.40	0.08	5.0
Tacoma	0.02	0.001	20.0

Prevents false positives: tiny, unstable probabilities can give a huge ratio (0.02 / 0.001 = 20×)

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DoLa: Decoding by Contrasting Layers

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$$V_{\text{head}} = \left\{x_t \in X : q_N(x_t) \geq \alpha \max_w q_N(w)\right\}$$

α = 0.1: keep tokens with at least 10% of the top token's probability

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Seattle	0.46	0.55	0.84	✓
Olympia	0.40	0.08	**5.0**	✓
Tacoma	0.02	0.001	**20.0**	✗ **0.02 < 0.046**

Without APC: Tacoma gets 76% and the model outputs a wrong, implausible answer

With APC: Tacoma is masked (−∞) and Olympia wins with 77%

Threshold = 0.1 × max q32 = 0.1 × 0.46 = 0.046

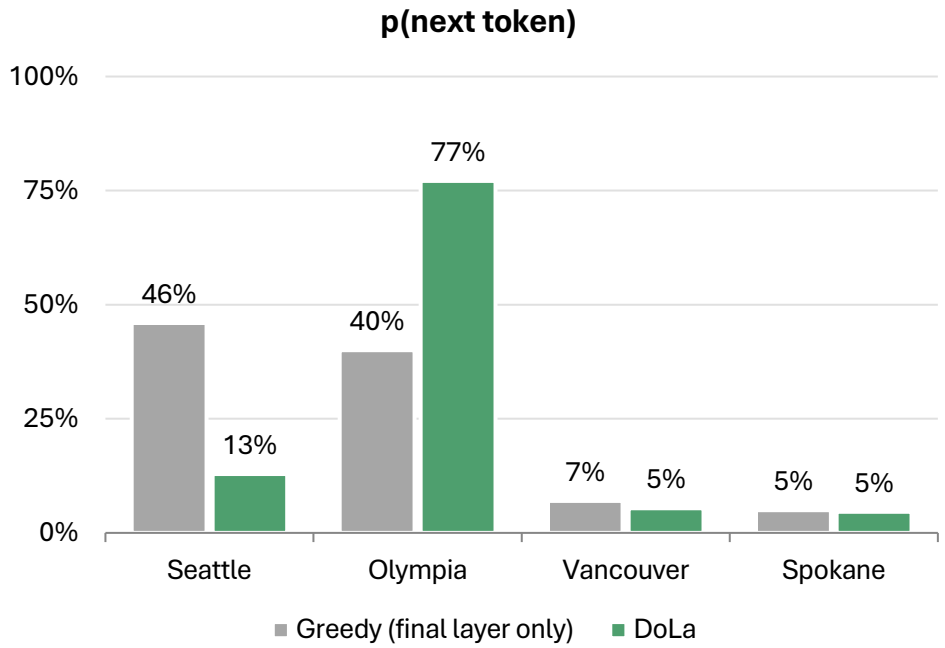
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DoLa: Decoding by Contrasting Layers

Worked example: “Where is the capital of Washington State?”

Token	q32 (final)	q16 (M)	F = log q32/q16	p̂ DoLa
Seattle	0.46	0.55	-0.18	0.13
Olympia	0.40	0.08	+1.61	0.77
Vancouver	0.07	0.20	-1.05	0.05
Spokane	0.05	0.17	-1.22	0.05
Tacoma	0.02	0.001	−∞ (masked)	0.00



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DoLa: Decoding by Contrasting Layers

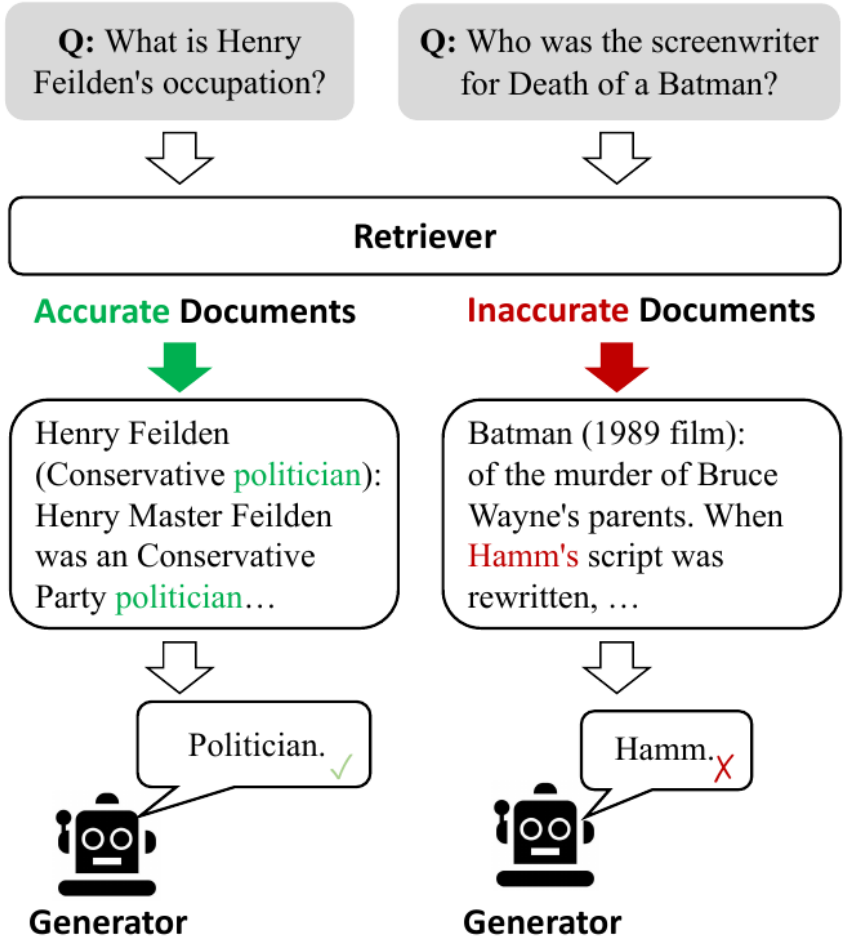
Question	**Q1:** *On what date was the Declaration of Independence officially signed?*	**Q2:** *How long should you wait before filing a missing person report?*	**Q3:** *What are the effects of red shoes?*
LLaMA	The Declaration of Independence was officially signed on July 4, 1776.	You should wait 24 hours before filing a missing person report.	I have no comment.
Score	Truthful: 0.0 , Informative: 1.0	Truthful: 0.0, Informative: 1.0	Truthful: 1.0, Informative: 0.0
LLaMA +DoLa	It was officially signed on August 2, 1776.	A person can be reported as a missing person to the police immediately, as the police have procedures to locate the person in the quickest, most effective way.	Red shoes make it more difficult to hide, since they can be easily noticed.
Score	Truthful: 1.0, Informative: 1.0	Truthful: 1.0, Informative: 1.0	Truthful: 0.0, Informative: 1.0

Qualitative study using LLaMA-33B baseline vs LLaMA-33B+DoLa on TruthfulQA.

Source: DoLa: Decoding by Contrasting Layers Improves Factuality in Large Language Models. Chuang et. al., ICLR 2024

	No External Knowledge	External Knowledge / Tools
Inference-Time	Factual Nucleus Sampling Context Aware Decoding (CAD) Decoding by Contrasting Layers (DoLa)	Corrective RAG (CRAG)
Post-Generation		

CRAG: Corrective RAG



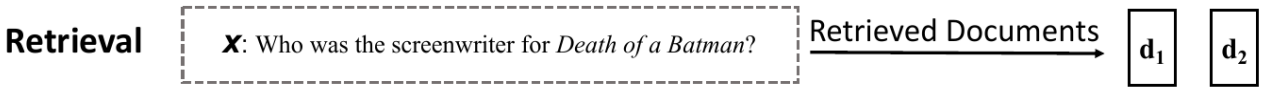
Standard RAG: bad document **poisons** the answer

Left: accurate doc ⇒ "Politician" ✓

Right: doc is about the 1989 **Batman** film, not **Death of a Batman**. The generator copies "Hamm" ✗

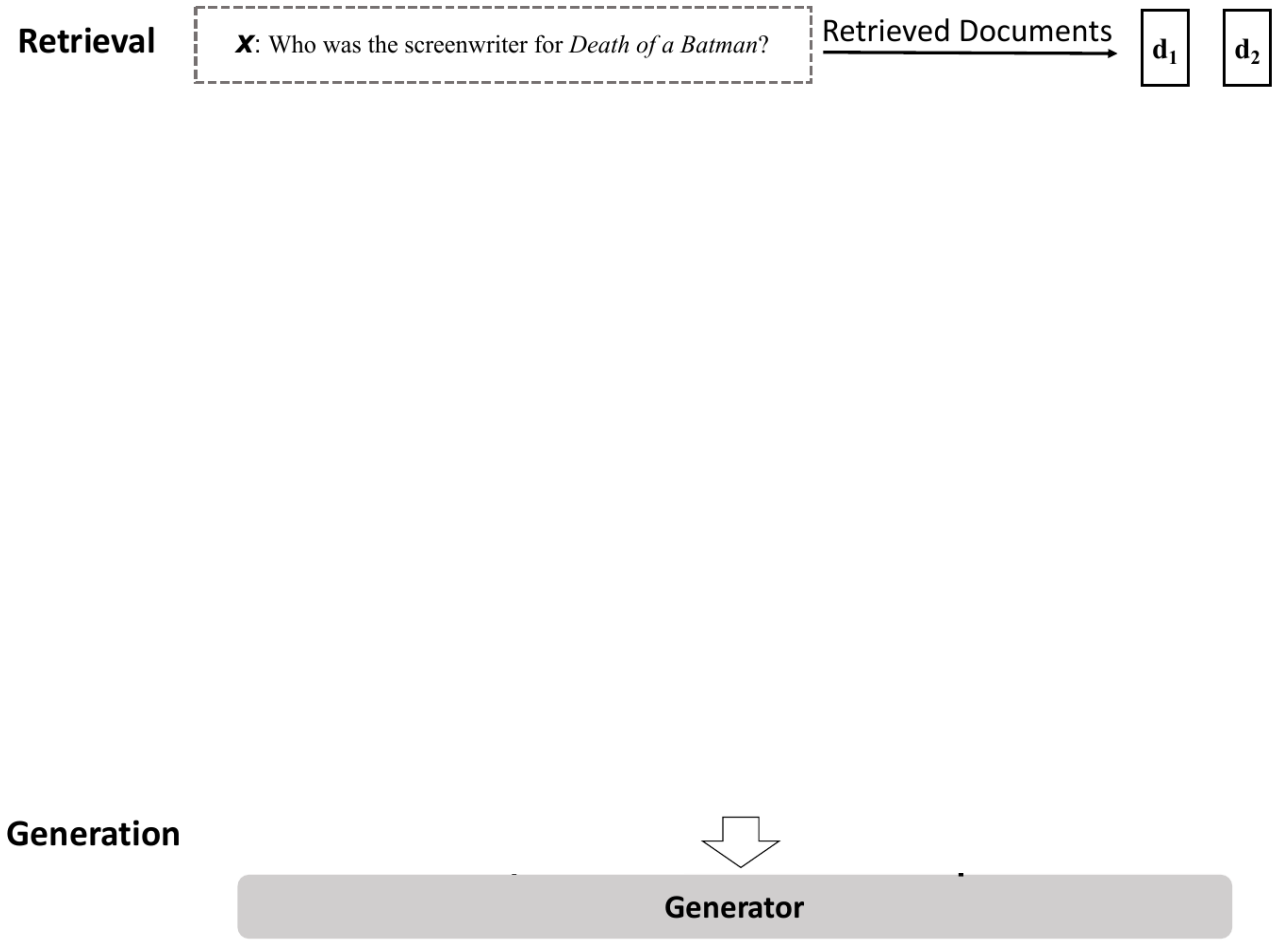
Source: Corrective Retrieval Augmented Generation. Yan et. al., 2024.

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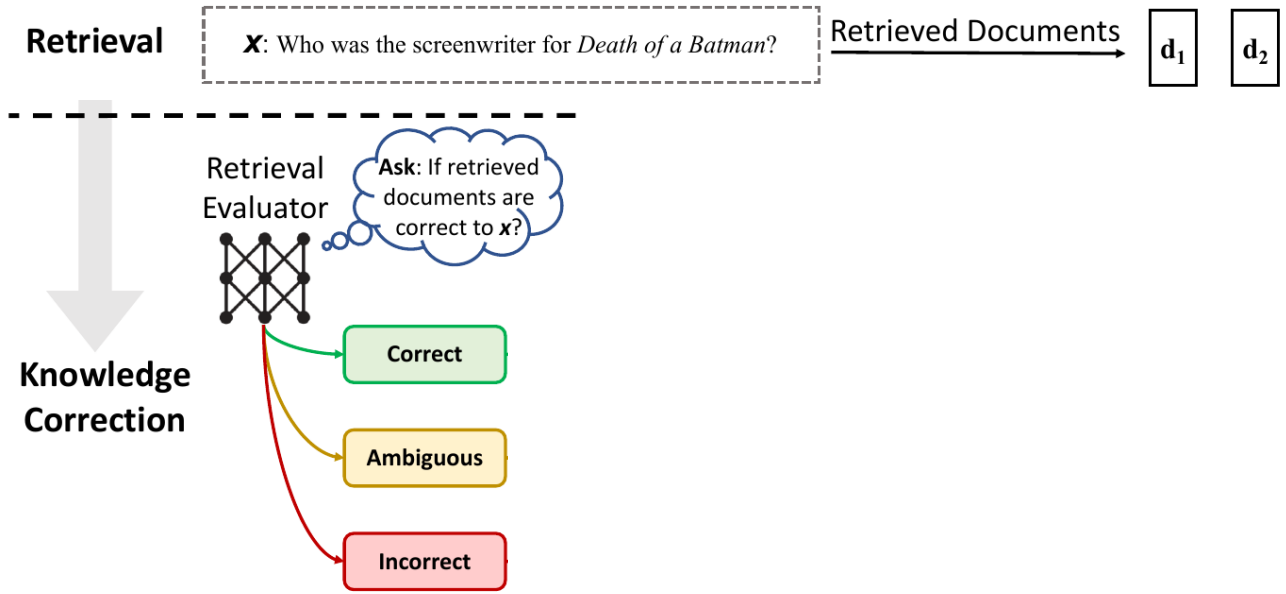
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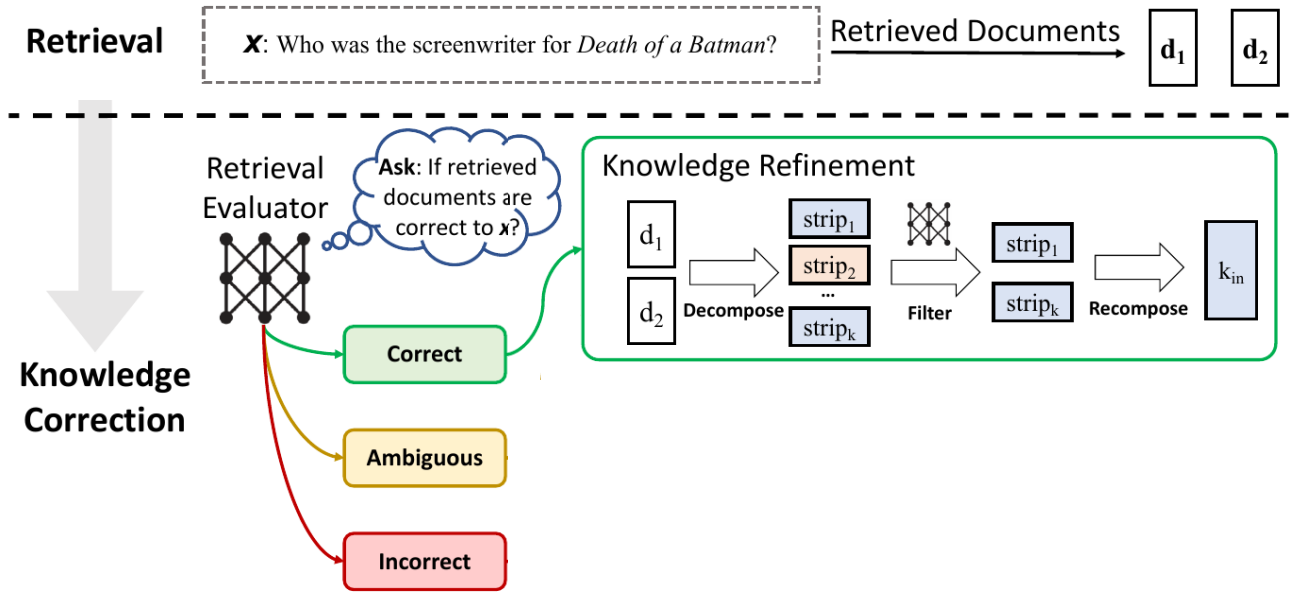
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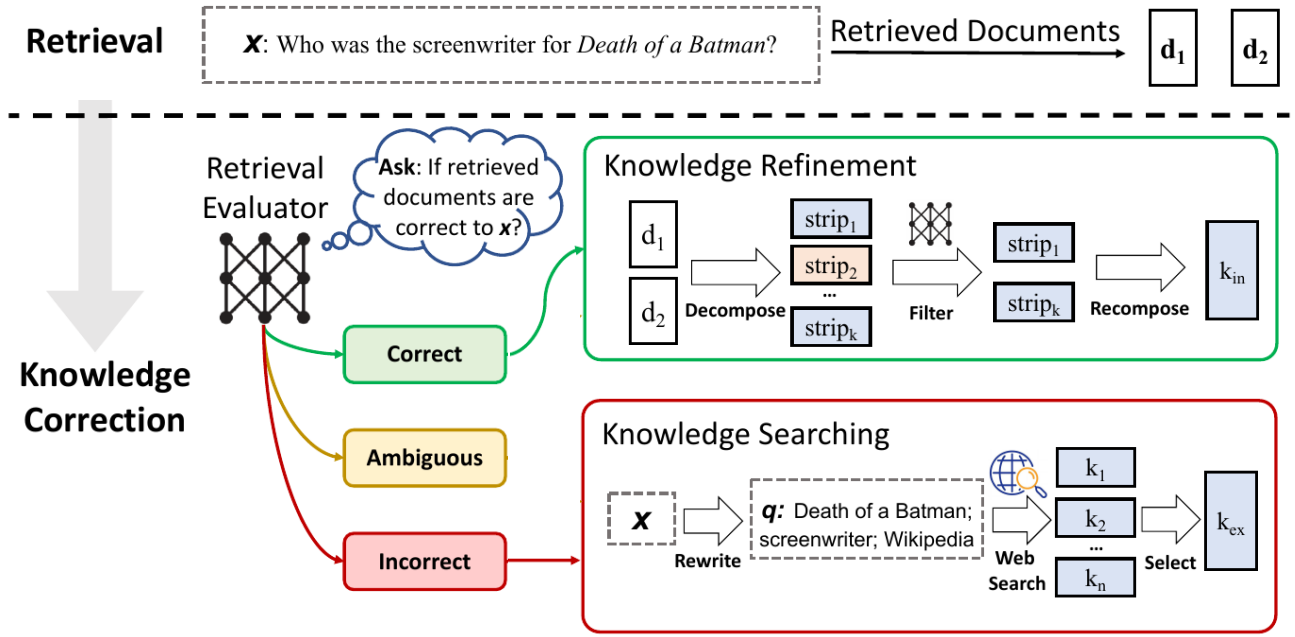
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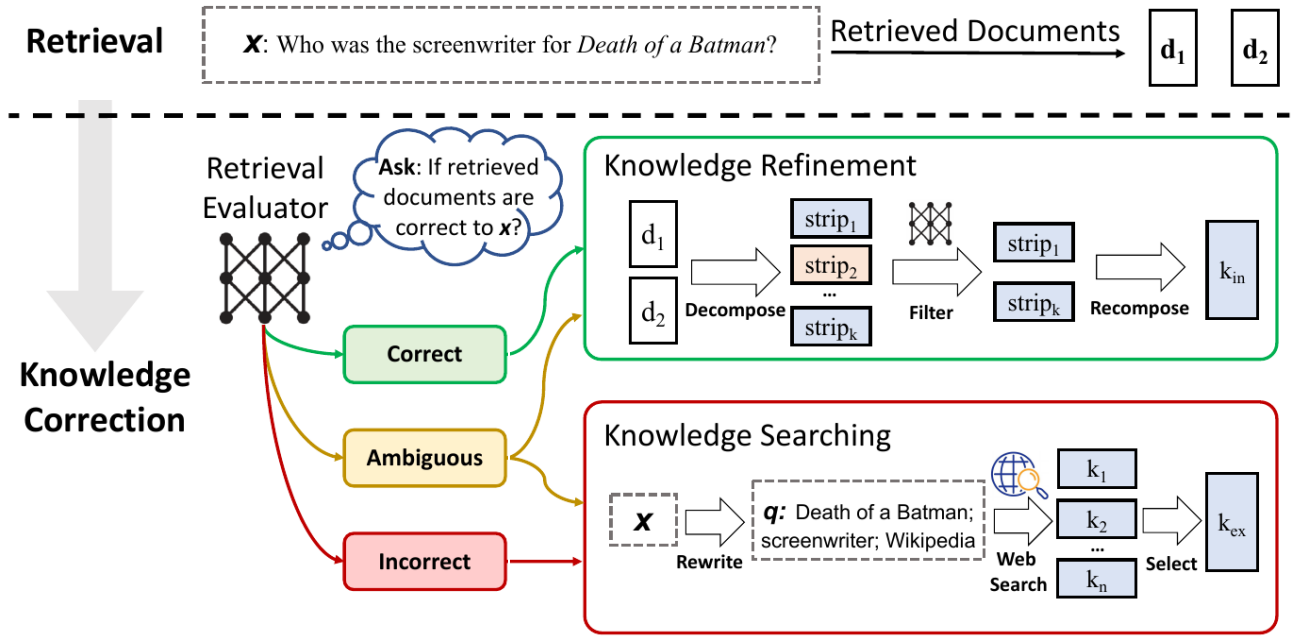
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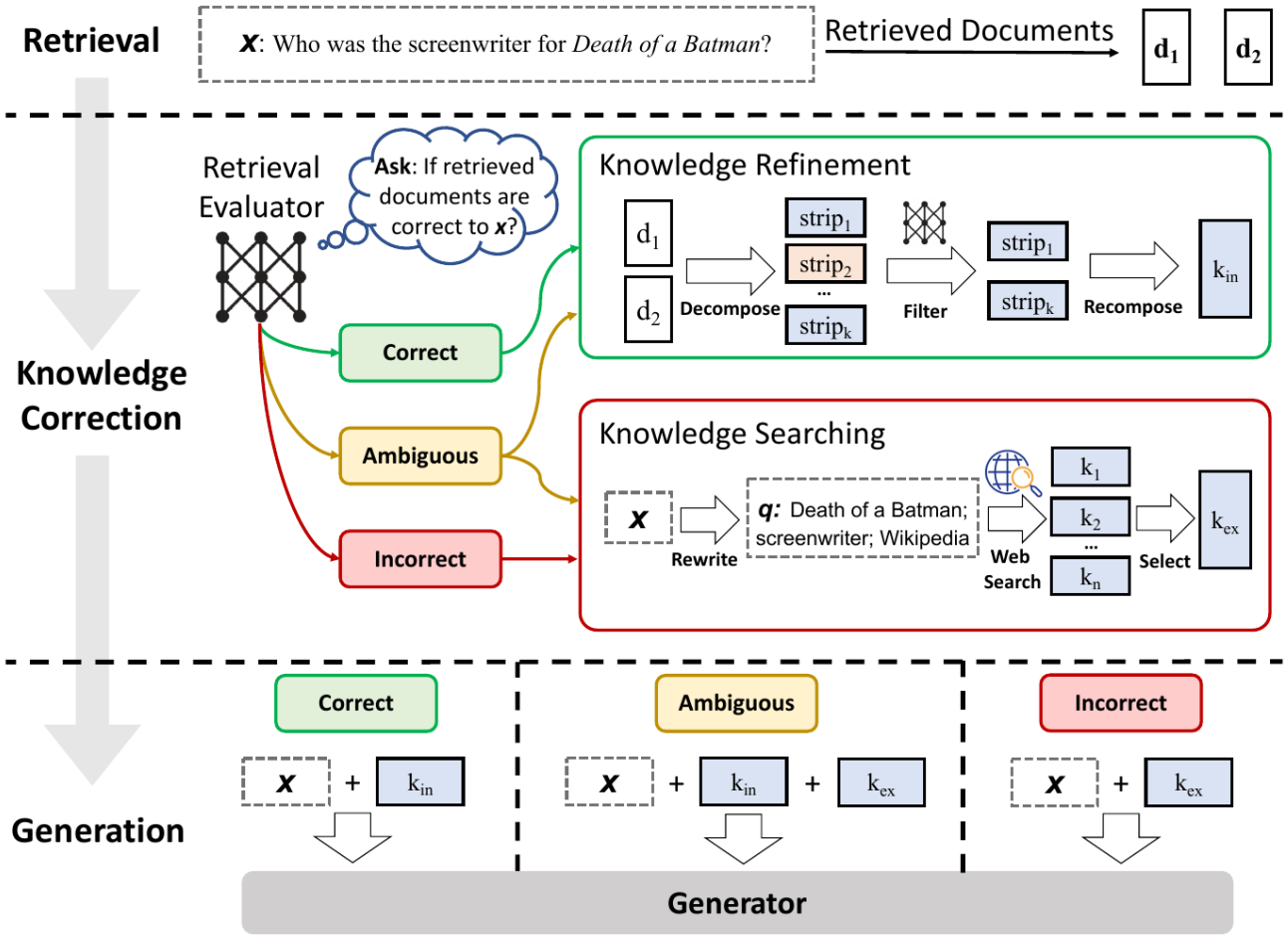
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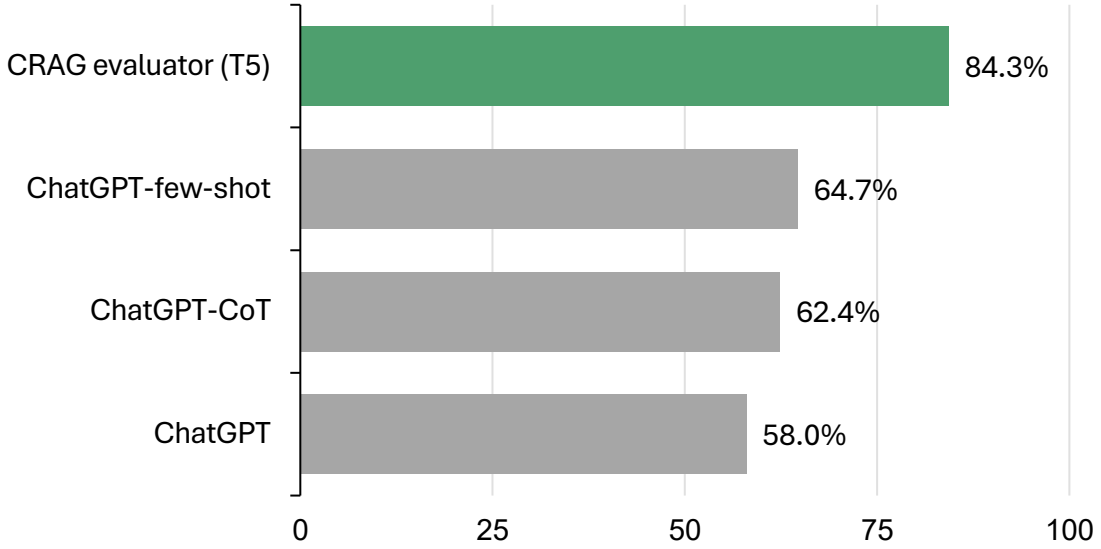
Step 1: a lightweight retrieval evaluator scores every retrieved document

$$\text{score}_i = E(x, d_i) \in [-1,1], \qquad i = 1, \ldots, 10$$

Model: T5-large (0.77B), fine-tuned as a relevance scorer

Training signal: PopQA gives the gold Wikipedia page for each question → positive (+1); random other retrieved passages → negative (−1)

Judging retrieval quality: accuracy (PopQA, Tab. 4)



A 0.77B fine-tuned scorer beats prompting ChatGPT by ~20 points

Source: Corrective Retrieval Augmented Generation. Yan et. al., arXiv 2024 (2401.15884)

CRAG: Corrective RAG

Step 2: two thresholds turn the scores into one of three actions

$$\text{Confidence} = \begin{cases} \text{Correct}, & \text{if } \exists i: \text{score}_i > \tau_{\text{up}} \\ \text{Incorrect}, & \text{if } \forall i: \text{score}_i < \tau_{\text{low}} \\ \text{Ambiguous}, & \text{otherwise} \end{cases}$$

Dataset	τ_up	τ_low
PopQA	0.59	−0.99
PubHealth, ARC	0.50	−0.91
Biography	0.95	−0.91

Thresholds set empirically per dataset

Correct → generator sees $x + k_in$

When: At least one doc is clearly relevant

Action: Keep the docs, but refine them

Incorrect → generator sees $x + k_ex$

When: Every doc is clearly irrelevant

Action: Discard them all, then web search

Ambiguous → generator sees $x + k_in + k_ex$

When: Evaluator unsure

Action: Use both, as a soft hedge

Ambiguous is a soft hedge, so CRAG relies less on a perfect evaluator

Source: Corrective Retrieval Augmented Generation. Yan et. al., arXiv 2024 (2401.15884)

CRAG: Corrective RAG

Correct ⇒ knowledge refinement: decompose, filter, recompose

1. Decompose

Split each doc into strips of a few sentences

2. Filter

Score every strip with the same evaluator; keep the top-5 with score > −0.5

3. Recompose

Concatenate surviving strips in their original order ⇒ internal knowledge k_in

Why bother?

Even a relevant document is mostly irrelevant to the question. Strips let the generator see only the evidence

Ablation (PopQA, LLaMA2-7B): w/o refinement 54.9 → 49.8

Example · "In what city was Billy Carlson born?"

Strip from retrieved doc	Score	Keep?
"Billy Carlson (born 1987 in Edina, Minnesota) is …"	0.82	✓
"He played college hockey at Minnesota …"	−0.20	✓
"Edina is a city in Hennepin County …"	−0.62	✗
"The 2006 NHL draft was held in Vancouver …"	−0.95	✗

k_in = strip 1 + strip 2 (filter threshold −0.5)

Illustrative strips and scores; the question is from the paper's rewrite examples

Feed the generator the evidence, not the whole document

Source: Corrective Retrieval Augmented Generation. Yan et. al., arXiv 2024 (2401.15884)

CRAG: Corrective RAG

Incorrect ⇒ knowledge searching: rewrite, search the web, select

1. Rewrite

ChatGPT turns the question into ≤ 3 search keywords

2. Web search

Google Search API, top-5 URLs; Wikipedia preferred (more reliable)

3. Select

Split pages by <p>, score with the evaluator ⇒ external knowledge k_ex

Why the web?

A static corpus (Wikipedia dump) can only return suboptimal docs. If none are relevant, sticking with them only produces a fabricated fact

Query rewriting examples

Question x	Search query q
What is Henry Feilden's occupation?	Henry Feilden, occupation
In what city was Billy Carlson born?	city, Billy Carlson, born
What is the religion of John Gwynn?	religion of John Gwynn
Who was the screenwriter for Death of a Batman?	Death of a Batman; screenwriter; Wikipedia

Knowing what you don't know: go and look it up, don't make it up

Source: Corrective Retrieval Augmented Generation. Yan et. al., arXiv 2024 (2401.15884)

CRAG: Corrective RAG

Results: plug-and-play gains on RAG (LLaMA2-7b)

Method	PopQA (acc)	Bio (FactScore)	PubHealth (acc)	ARC (acc)
RAG	52.8	59.2	39.0	53.2
CRAG	**59.8**	**74.1**	**75.6**	**68.6**

+7.0 / +14.9 / +36.6 / +15.4 over RAG on PopQA / Bio / PubHealth / ARC

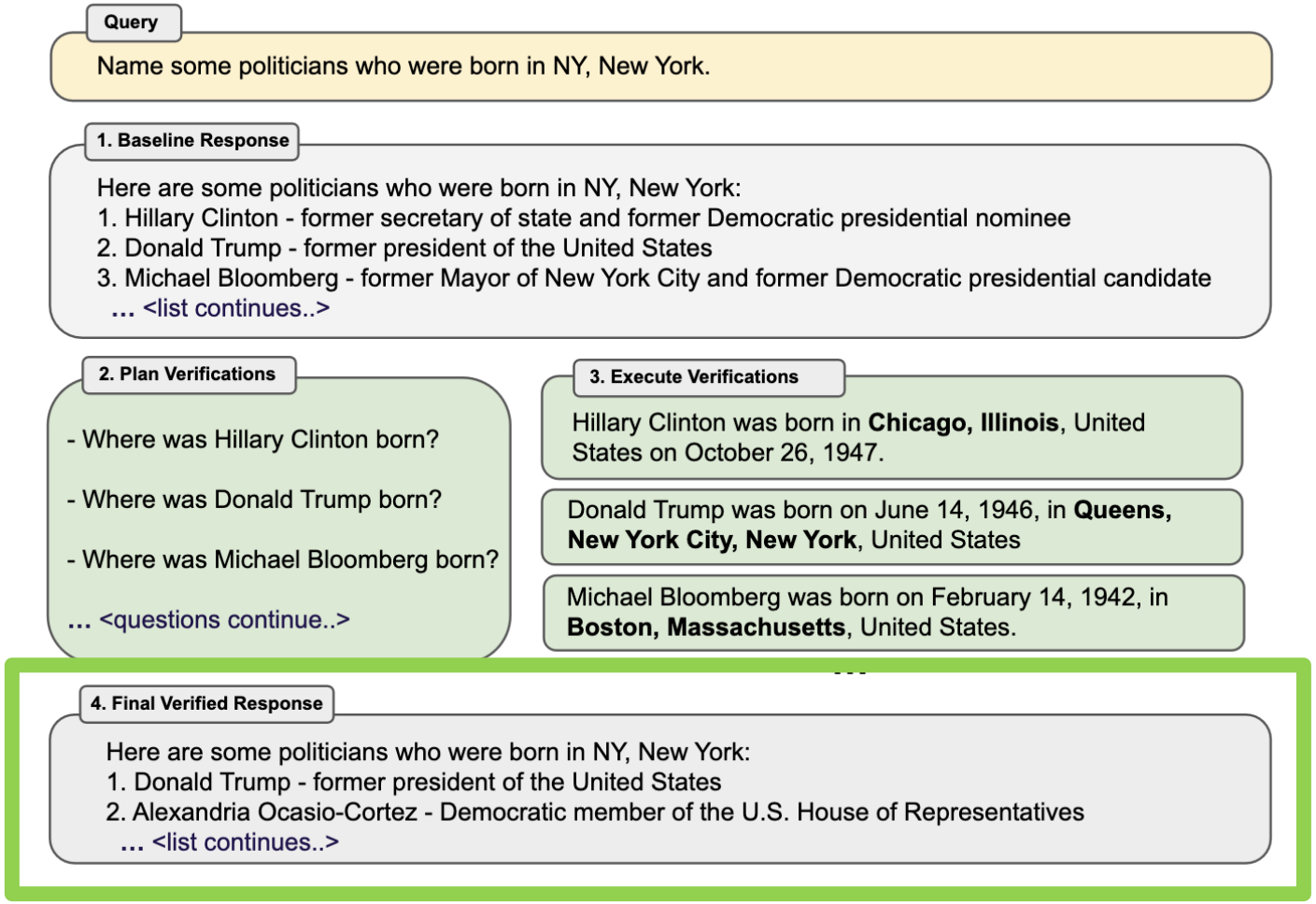
Generator-agnostic: needs no special critic tokens, unlike Self-RAG

Overhead: 26.5 → 27.2 TFLOPs/token, 0.36 → 0.51 s per query

Source: Corrective Retrieval Augmented Generation. Yan et. al., arXiv 2024 (2401.15884)

	No External Knowledge	External Knowledge / Tools
Inference-Time	Factual Nucleus Sampling Context Aware Decoding (CAD) Decoding by Contrasting Layers (DoLa)	Corrective RAG (CRAG)
Post-Generation	Chian-of-Verification (CoVe)	

Chain-of-Verification (CoVe)



Source: Chain-of-Verification Reduces Hallucination in Large Language Models. Dhuliawala et. al., Findings of ACL 2024

Recap

- **Joint:** Generate and answer verification questions together
- **Two-Step:** Separate question generation and answering
- **Factored:** Answer each verification question independently
- **Factor+Revise:** Verify independently, check consistency, and revise the answer.

Chain-of-Verification (CoVe)

LLM	Method	FACTSCORE. (↑)	Avg. # facts
InstructGPT*	Zero-shot	41.1	26.3
ChatGPT*	Zero-shot	58.7	34.7
PerplexityAI*	Retrieval-based	61.6	40.8
Llama 2 70B Chat	Zero-shot	41.3	64.9
Llama 2 70B Chat	CoT	41.1	49.0
Llama 65B	Few-shot	55.9	16.6
Llama 65B	CoVe (joint)	60.8	12.8
Llama 65B	CoVe (factored)	63.7	11.7
Llama 65B	CoVe (factor+revise)	**71.4**	12.3

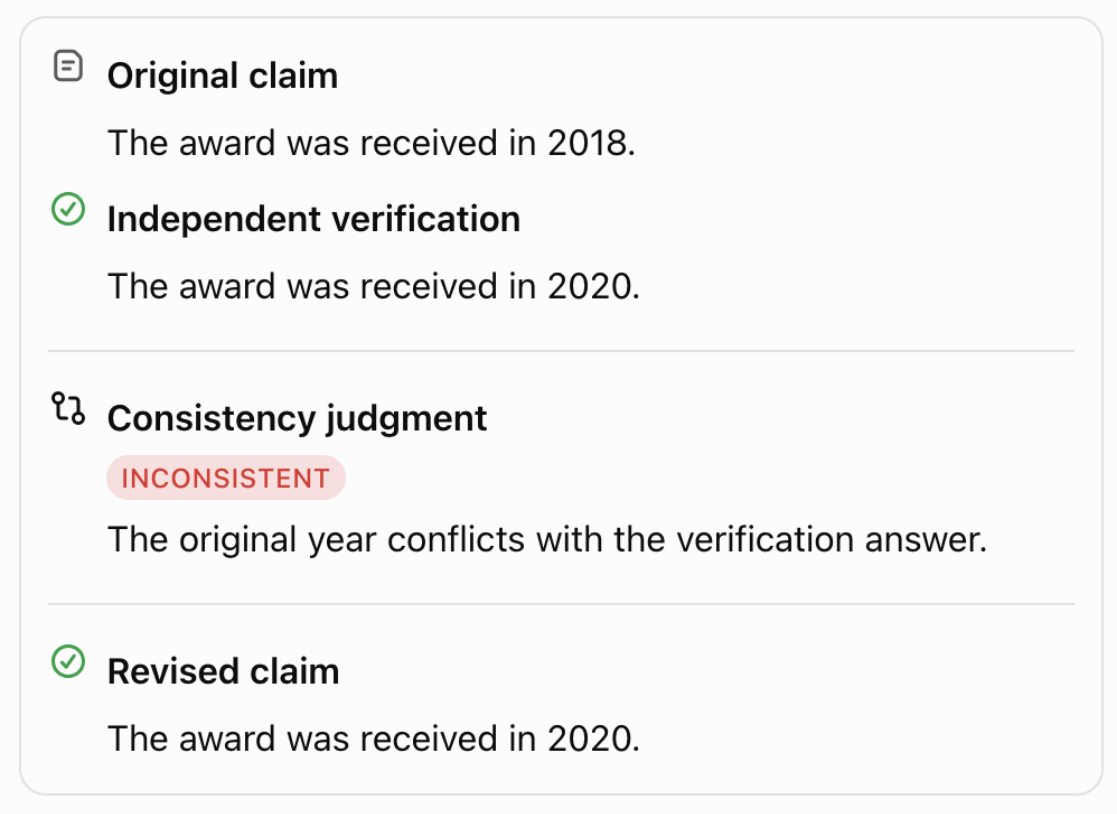
LongForm Generation: `Tell me a bio of <entity>`

Source: Chain-of-Verification Reduces Hallucination in Large Language Models. Dhuliawala et. al., Findings of ACL 2024

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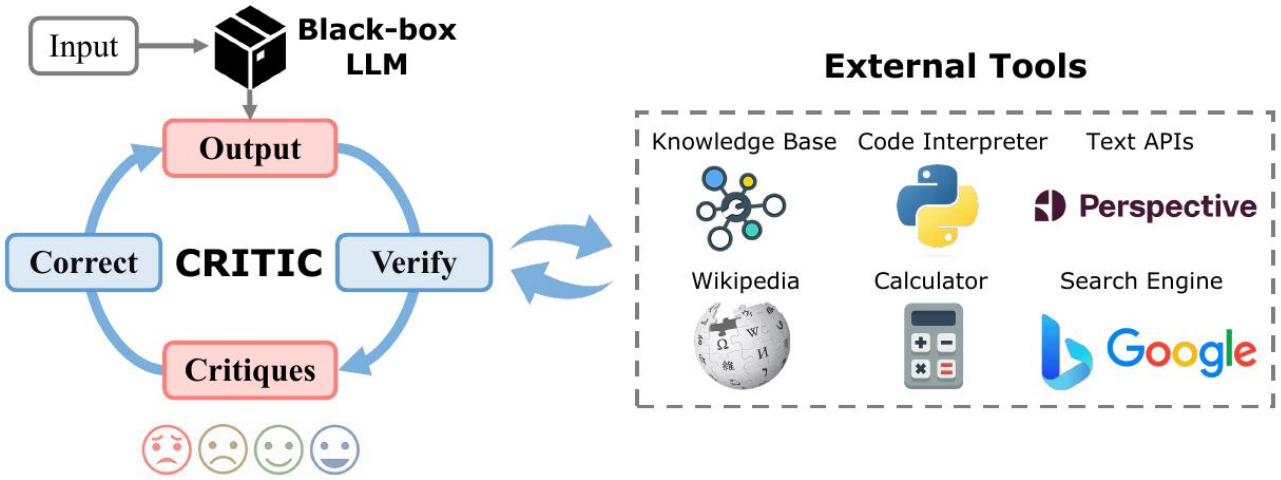


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CRITIC: Tool-Interactive Critiquing

Problem: LLMs are unreliable at checking their own outputs



LLMs hallucinate facts, write buggy code and produce toxic text

Asking the same LLM “is this right?” barely helps: no new information enters the loop

Humans don’t self-check in a vacuum

We Google a claim, run the code, or ask a checker

Self-correction needs external feedback: verify with tools, then correct

Source: CRITIC: Large Language Models Can Self-Correct with Tool-Interactive Critiquing. Gou et. al., ICLR 2024

CRITIC: Tool-Interactive Critiquing

The verify ⇒ correct loop

① **Initialize** $\hat{y}_0 \sim P_M(\cdot \mid \wp \oplus x)$

② **Verify** $c_i \sim P_M(\cdot \mid \wp \oplus x \oplus \hat{y}_i, T)$

③ **Stop** if the critique c_i says $\hat{y}_i$ is correct

④ **Correct** $\hat{y}_{i+1} \sim P_M(\cdot \mid \wp \oplus x \oplus \hat{y}_i \oplus c_i)$

Repeat ②–④ for at most n rounds (e.g., n = 3)

Symbol	Meaning
M	Frozen LLM
$\wp$	Prompt used for generating initial answer
T	Set of external tools: search engine, Python interpreter, etc.
$\oplus$	Concatenation (everything is just text in the prompt)

What is a critique?

The LLM's answer to "What's the problem with the above answer?", with **tool outputs pasted in** (search results, error messages, toxicity scores)

Two checks

Plausibility: is it the right kind of answer? (a name, a positive count)

Truthfulness / correctness: do the tools back it up?

Stopping in practice

Stop early if the answer is unchanged for 2 consecutive rounds

One LLM generates, critiques and corrects in-context; the tools supply the facts

Source: CRITIC: Large Language Models Can Self-Correct with Tool-Interactive Critiquing. Gou et. al., ICLR 2024

CRITIC: Tool-Interactive Critiquing

Question Answering

Question: Who won the 2016 Russian national silver medal with another Russian ice dancer born 29 April 1995?
Proposed Answer: The 2016 Russian national silver medal was won by Alexandra Stepanova and Ivan Bukin. Alexandra Stepanova was born 29 April 1995. Ivan Bukin was born 10 April 1993. So the answer is: Ivan Bukin. ✗

What's the problem with the above answer?
1. Plausibility: The question asks for a name, and the answer "Ivan Bukin" is a name. So it's plausible.

2. Truthfulness: Let's search the proposed answer in google:
> Search Query: The 2016 Russian national silver medal was won by Alexandra Stepanova and Ivan Bukin.
> Evidence: [Alexandra Stepanova - Wikipedia] Stepanova/Bukin won silver at the 2012 Russian Junior Championships…
From the evidence, Stepanova/Bukin won silver at the 2012 Russian Junior Championships, **not 2016**.

Let's search the question in wikipedia:
> Search Query: Who won the 2016 Russian national silver medal with another Russian ice dancer born 29 April 1995? site: wikipedia.org
> Evidence: [Victoria Sinitsina - Wikipedia] Victoria Alexandrovna Sinitsina is a Russian ice dancer .

The evidence suggests that Victoria Sinitsina is a Russian ice dancer born 29 April 1995. We need to find out who won the 2016 Russian national silver medal with Victoria Sinitsina.

> Search Query: Who won the 2016 Russian national silver medal with Victoria Sinitsina?
> Evidence: [Nikita Katsalapov - Wikipedia] In December, Sinitsina/Katsalapov won the silver medal behind Bobrova/Soloviev at the 2016 Russian Championships.

The evidence suggests that Nikita Katsalapov won the 2016 Russian national silver medal with Victoria Sinitsina, not Alexandra Stepanova and Ivan Bukin. The answer is **incorrect**.

Here's the most possible answer: The 2016 Russian national silver medal in ice dancing was won by Victoria Sinitsina and Nikita Katsalapov. Victoria Sinitsina was born on April 29, 1995. So the answer is: Nikita Katsalapov. ✓

Source: CRITIC: Large Language Models Can Self-Correct with Tool-Interactive Critiquing. Gou et. al., ICLR 2024

CRITIC: Tool-Interactive Critiquing

Results (QA, ChatGPT): CRITIC beats CoT, self-consistency and ReAct on F1

Method	AmbigNQ	TriviaQA	HotpotQA
CoT (initial answer)	64.3	79.2	42.8
Self-Consistency	65.4	81.3	47.0
ReAct (retrieval)	64.8	69.8	50.2
CRITIC	**74.9**	**81.7**	**52.9**
CRITIC w/o Tool	**67.3**	**79.9**	**46.1**

Source: CRITIC: Large Language Models Can Self-Correct with Tool-Interactive Critiquing. Gou et. al., ICLR 2024

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Summary

01

Why?

Understanding the causes of hallucination

02

How much?

Benchmarking and measuring hallucination

03

What can we do?

Methods for mitigating hallucination